

SI 529 Online Communities

*Winter 2026 Course Syllabus**

Instructor: Dr. Michaelanne Thomas

GSI: Hibby Thach

Class meetings: Wednesdays, 1:30-4:30 pm; Class location: 1240 LCSIB

- ★ Lectures will be recorded and available for viewing afterwards; with prior permission, some Q&As with guest speakers will be recorded; groupwork will not be recorded.



Note: This syllabus is subject to change and updates throughout the semester; changes made after the first class will be announced in class (when applicable) and via Canvas (always).

Course Summary

Online communities are central to how we work, play, learn, protest, socialize, and more. But why are some successful and some fail? How can we improve interactions and experiences in online communities, facilitate positive outcomes like social support and connectedness, while reducing negative outcomes like various kinds of harm?

In this course, we will be introduced to social science concepts and theories such as identity and self-presentation and some principles of designing online communities, and will practice to apply them in a variety of online contexts. This course will engage with hard topics that are relevant to online communities today, including race, gender, disability, health, politics, violence, misinformation, and ethics.

This course requires reading about online communities research, critiquing, and connecting theory to practice. The course includes both individual and group components. Projects include original research about online communities and developing ideas for new online communities.

We cannot possibly cover everything related to online communities in this class, and that is okay. There are so many critical and exciting topics to learn about online communities. We will use the class readings, discussions, assignments, activities, guest speakers, and space as a starting point. You will have opportunities to go beyond these topics to increase the breadth of everyone's learning (e.g., through participating in extra credit points), as well as to go in depth about a particular topic through your [online community study](#) and final design or research project. If you are more interested in the design aspects of online communities, you can select to do your final assignment in the *design track*, and if you are more interested in the research aspects of online communities, you can select the *research track*.

This course **does not teach** research methods, how to write, interaction design, or team work dynamics. This is an upper-level course, which means that you are expected to supplement your learning with other courses and resources. For example, if you want to know more about research methods to apply it to your project, you are expected to do your own research. **You can always reach out to the instructors and the GSI for guidance**, but taking initiative and ownership is important and expected.

Instructional Team

Anonymous Feedback Form: We welcome your feedback to help improve the course experience. You're always encouraged to drop by office hours for a conversation, but if you prefer, you can also use [\[Form link\]](#) to share your thoughts. The form is open throughout the semester, so feel free to submit feedback at any time.

(See the [Communication with the Instruction Team section](#))

Instructor Dr. Michaelanne Thomas

- Email: mmtd@umich.edu
- Office hours: Tuesdays 1-2 pm via Zoom (the link will be generated via the scheduling link). Please schedule at least 24hr in advance: <https://calendar.app.google/Lx1rNAZzZf5whkgeA>. If this time doesn't work for you, please email me.
- Pronouns: she/her/hers

GSI Hibby Thach

- Email: hibby@umich.edu
- Office hours: Thursdays 4-5pm or by appointment, via Zoom: <https://umich.zoom.us/j/97319680756>
- Pronouns: she/her/hers

IA Rebecca Yedid

- Please do not contact the IA.

Learning Objectives

After taking this course, you should be able to:

- Understand important features of interactions on online communities
- Assess an online community using the vocabulary and concepts of theoretical frameworks
- Analyze online interactions critically
- Consider and discuss the ethical implications of online communities
- Understand, discuss, and shape research topics in the online communities field

Course Schedule – guest speakers may be added during the semester.

Date	Lecture Topic	Readings (to be completed on day listed, unless otherwise noted)	Assignments (due on Wednesdays by 1 pm before class unless otherwise noted)
Jan 7	Week 1: Introduction to online communities, SI 529, and each other	Bruckman, A. (2022). Chapter 1: Are Online “Communities” Really Communities? in <i>Should You Believe Wikipedia? Online Communities and the Construction of Knowledge</i> (pp. 8-31). Cambridge University Press. Kraut, R. & Resnik, P. (2012). Chapter 1: Introduction. In R. Kraut, P. Resnick, S. Kiesler, M. Burke, Y.Chen, N. Kittur, J. Konstan, Y. Ren, and J.Riedl (Eds), Building Successful Online Communities: Evidence-Based Social Design (pp. 1-17). MIT Press.	DUE: Read syllabus and bring any questions to class First week survey (due by Jan 7 at 11:59 PM) Read the readings for the first day (no responses due)
Jan 14	Week 2: Ethics of studying and designing online communities	Bruckman, A. & Hudson, J. (2004). "Go Away": Participants Objections to Being Studied and the Ethics of Chatroom Research. <i>The Information Society</i> 21, 127-139. Fiesler, C. & Proferes, N. (2018). "Participant" Perceptions of Twitter Research Ethics. <i>Social Media + Society</i>, 4(1), Klassen, S., & Fiesler, C. (2022). "This Isn't Your Data, Friend": Black Twitter as a Case Study on Research Ethics for Public Data. <i>Social Media + Society</i>, 8(4).	DUE: Reading response for week 2 Black Mirror In-Class workshop (1 point) Teams for online community study will be assigned Collaboration plan for online community study (due end of class)
Jan 21	Week 3: Design and online communities	Resnik, P., Konstan, J., Chen, Y., and Kraut, R. (2012). Chapter 6: Starting New Online Communities. In R. Kraut, P. Resnick, S. Kiesler, M. Burke, Y.Chen, N. Kittur, J. Konstan, Y. Ren, and J.Riedl (Eds), Building Successful	DUE: Reading response for week 3 Project management plan for online community study

		Online Communities: Evidence-Based Social Design (pp. 231-277). MIT Press. Ren, Y., Kraut, R., Kiesler, S. (2007). Applying Common Identity and Bond Theory to Design of Online Communities. Organizational Studies. Kim, A, Nine Principles of Community Design.	Proposal for online community study
Jan 28	Week 4: Identity and online communities	Donathan, J. (2014). Chapter 9: Constructing Identity in <i>The Social Machine</i>. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. Bruckman, A. (2022) Chapter 5: How Do People Express Identity Online, and Why Is This Important for Online Interaction? In <i>Should You Believe Wikipedia? Online Communities and the Construction of Knowledge</i> Cambridge University Press. Davis, J. L., & Chouinard, J. B. (2016). Theorizing affordances: From request to refuse. Bulletin of science, technology & society, 36(4), 241-248.	DUE: Reading response for week 4 Receive approval/feedback from instructional team for online community study [teams will brief the class during class if time permits]
Feb 4	Week 5: Regulation and moderation of online communities	Chapter 6: What Is Bad Online Behavior, and What Can We Do About It? In <i>Should You Believe Wikipedia? Online Communities and the Construction of Knowledge</i> by Amy Bruckman. Cambridge University Press, 2022. Gillespie, T. (2018) "CHAPTER 1. All Platforms Moderate". <i>Custodians of the Internet: Platforms, Content Moderation, and the Hidden Decisions That Shape Social Media</i>, pp. 1-23. New Haven: Yale University Press. https://doi.org/10.12987/9780300235029-001	DUE: Reading response for week 5

		Thach, H., Mayworm, S., Delmonaco, D., & Haimson, O. (2022). (In)visible moderation: A digital ethnography of marginalized users and content moderation on Twitch and Reddit. <i>New Media & Society</i>, 26(7), 4034-4055. https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448221109804	
Feb 11	Week 6: Marginalization and online communities	Peterson-Salahuddin, S. (2022). Posting Back: Exploring Platformed Black Feminist Communities on Twitter and Instagram <i>Social Media + Society</i> 8(1). Ringland, K., Wolf, C. Faucett, H., Dombrowski, L., & Hayes, G. (2016). "Will I always be not social?" Re-Conceptualizing Sociality in the Context of a Minecraft Community for Autism <i>Proceedings of CHI 2016</i>, May 7-12, San Jose, CA,, pp. 1256–1269. DeVito, M.A., & Walker, A. (2020). "More gay" fits in better": Intracommunity Power Dynamics and Harms in Online LGBTQ+ Spaces. <i>Proceedings of CHI 2020</i>, April 25-30, Honolulu, HI, pp. 1-14.	DUE: Reading response for week 6 Survey to select a design or research track for the final project released during class (due Feb 11, 11:59 pm)
Feb 18	Week 7: Online Community Study Presentations	NO READINGS DUE	DUE: Online community study paper Online community study slides/presentation Final project teams announced before class. Self and peer evaluation (due Feb 18, 11:59 PM)
Feb 25	Week 8: Algorithms and	Algorithmic Folk Theories and Identity: How TikTok Users Engage in	DUE: Reading response for week 8

	online communities	Algorithmic Resistance and Identity Co-Production by Nadia Karizat, Dan Delmonaco, Motahhare Eslami, and Nazanin Andalibi. CSCW '21, October 2021, pp. 1-26. User Attitudes towards Algorithmic Opacity and Transparency in Online Reviewing Platforms by Motahhare Eslami, Kristen Vaccaro, Min Kyung Lee, Amit Elazari bar On, Eric Gilbert, and Karrie Karahalios. Proceedings of CHI 2019, May 2019, pp. 1-14 Lee, A. Y., Mieczkowski, H., Ellison, N. B., & Hancock, J. T. (2022). The algorithmic crystal: Conceptualizing the self through algorithmic personalization on TikTok. Proceedings of the ACM on Human-computer Interaction, 06(CSCW2), 1-22.	In Class: Midterm feedback survey
Mar 4	Week 9: SPRING BREAK	NO READINGS DUE	
Mar 11	Week 10: Wellbeing and online communities	No one knows exactly what social media is doing to teens. By K. Tiffany. The Atlantic, 2023. (available on Canvas > Files) Weinstein, E. (2018). The social media see-saw: Positive and negative influences on adolescents' affective well-being. New Media & Society, 20(10), 3597-3623. Sheng, J. T., & Kairam, S. R. (2020). From virtual strangers to irl friends: relationship development in livestreaming communities on twitch. Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction, 4(CSCW2), 1-34.	DUE: Reading response for week 10 Collaboration plan for final project Project management plan for final project Final project study proposal

Mar 18	Week 11: Abuse, harassment, and extremism on online communities	Many Faced Hate: A Cross Platform Study of Content Framing and Information Sharing by Online Hate Groups by Shruti Phadke and Tanushree Mitra. Proceedings of CHI 2020, April 2020, pp. 1-13 The Black Feminists Who Saw the Alt-Right Threat Coming by Rachelle Hampton. Slate, 2019.	DUE: Reading response for week 11
Mar 25	Week 12: Access, constraint, and (online) communities of survival	Un grano de arena: Infrastructural care, social media platforms, and the Venezuelan humanitarian crisis. By Michaelanne Thomas. (2021) Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction, 4(CSCW3), pp.1-28. Digital Resilience Tactics of Syrian Refugees in the Netherlands: Social Media for Social Support, Health, and Identity by Ghadeer Udwan, Koen Leurs, and Amanda Alencar. Social Media + Society, 2020. For Many in Venezuela, Social Media Is A Matter of Life And Death. By Jasmine Garsd. 2018. NPR.	DUE: Reading response for week 12
Apr 1	Week 13: Misinformation, conspiracy theories, and online communities	Moran, R. E., Grasso, I., & Koltai, K. (2022). Folk Theories of Avoiding Content Moderation: How Vaccine-Opposed Influencers Amplify Vaccine Opposition on Instagram. <i>Social Media+ Society</i>, 8(4), 20563051221144252. Marwick, A.E. & Partin, W.C. (2022). Constructing alternative facts: Populist expertise and the QAnon conspiracy. <i>New Media & Society</i>, (26)5, 2535-2555. Freelon, D. & Lokot, T. (2020). Russian Twitter disinformation campaigns reach across the American	DUE: Reading response for week 13

		political spectrum . Harvard Kennedy School Misinformation Review.	
Apr 8	Week 14: TBA	TBA	DUE: Reading response for week 14
Apr 15	Week 15: Final Project Presentations	NO READINGS DUE	DUE: Project slides: Design Track or Research Track Project paper/report: Design Track or Research Track Self and peer evaluations (due Apr 15, 11:59 PM)

Post Covid-19 Classroom: Culture of Care

For the safety of all students, faculty, and staff on campus, it is important for each of us to be mindful of safety measures that have been put in place for our protection. By returning to campus, you have acknowledged your responsibility for protecting the collective health of our community. **Your participation in this course on an in-person basis is conditional upon your adherence to all safety measures mandated by the State of Michigan and the University, including being vaccinated or receiving an exemption.** Please reach out to the instructional team if you are experiencing challenges and we can discuss how to adjust the course to meet your needs. The main goal here is for you to learn, and we are here to help support you in learning.

In addition, we have some class norms:

- If you are feeling ill do not come to class.
- If you have been exposed to Covid-19 and suspect that you may be infected, even if not symptomatic, please take a test and only attend the class if you test negative.

Your grade will not be negatively impacted by not attending class due to illness or your need to care for those who are ill. We ask that you let us know as soon as possible if/when this becomes relevant to you.

Class Recordings

This is an in-person class. There are no options to zoom in. However, we will be doing audio and video recording of all sessions to enable those who cannot attend class in person on a given day to access the content. These recordings will not be made available publicly. Recordings of all sessions will be available on Canvas only to students registered for this class. As part of your participation in this course, you may be recorded. If you do not wish to be recorded, please contact the professor during the first week of class to discuss alternative arrangements. The camera only picks up the front of the room (instructor and slides), but this may require you to sit in a particular place in the room, outside the cameras' view. Students may not copy and share the lecture videos with those not in the class, or upload them to any other online environment (this is a violation of the Federal Education Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA)).

Personal recordings are prohibited except with permission

Students are prohibited from recording/distributing any class activity without written permission from the instructor, except as necessary as part of approved accommodations for students with disabilities. Any approved recordings may only be used for the student's own private use.

Course Format

This course will involve synchronous interaction between the instructor and students. Classes will involve lectures, in-class activities, discussions, and group work. Some activities will involve the whole class, and other activities will require small group interaction. Please see the [Attendance and Class Participation](#) section for more information about our expectations for student participation in class.

Team Work

There are two team-based assignments for this class: [Online Community Study](#) and [Final Research/Design Assignment](#). There are assignments in this course to facilitate and scaffold your teamwork for both team projects.

All class activities and assignments are the same for all students. However, close to half way through the semester, students will choose a research or a design track for their final group assignment.

The main difference this makes in the student experience is the choice of the final deliverable being design or research-focused. At that point, we will randomly assign students into (possibly new) teams taking into consideration the survey you will fill out in week 6. Teams who have worked together for the Online Community Study assignment and would like to stick together for either track can do so. Otherwise, students will be placed in teams with others interested in the same track. You may not change your mind about the research or design track once you have declared your interest in one because with the time that we have in the class, switching tracks and projects will be very difficult to manage, so give it some thought and read the assignment descriptions before picking one.

For all team assignments, you are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You will fill out self and peer evaluation forms twice during the semester. You will also develop a project management plan and a collaboration plan for each one of your team projects. These are in place to support your accountability to each other.

If a student does not contribute to their group work appropriately or their conduct is not professional/respectful (more on that below), their grades on the associated assignments *as well as* their group contribution/professionalism work will be affected.

For team assignments, it is expected that you are truly collaborating with your team members and that each of you is contributing to the assignments equally. Everyone is responsible for what is submitted as a group deliverable (not just the person submitting the assignment on behalf of the team), and should be able to explain all parts of a submission and answer questions. **If your group dynamics (with one or more members) are problematic, please let the instructional team know as soon as you notice, so that we can help you manage your team dynamics if needed** -- it is hard to help students when they wait until a late point in the semester to share challenges such as a team member not doing their part or being unreliable for whatever reason.

More on Teamwork. Good teamwork is an essential skill in any knowledge-work career, and it will be important for success in this course. One of the best predictors of good teamwork is the degree to which team members contribute equally ([Woolley et al. 2015](#)). If you are someone who tends to dominate conversation, please make an effort to ask other team members for their thoughts. If you are someone who tends to be quiet, please make an effort to speak up.

Common challenges may include: (1) a team member shows disrespect or causes offense to another team member; (2) team members have substantial personality conflicts with one another; or (3) some team members do not do their fair share of the work for the team, do not respond to team messages in a timely manner, do not show up to meetings, make decisions without consulting others, etc. Whatever the case, if you feel you have difficulty with one or more team members, please let your instructional team know right away.

Problem (1) is unacceptable. We expect master's students to be adults who are capable of treating one another with respect, regardless of differences in background, identity, nationality, or first language. If you feel a teammate has treated you with disrespect, please do not hesitate to let the instructional team know. At the same time, please also give one another the benefit of the doubt – people may not always intend something the way you receive it.

Problems (2) and (3) are problems that most of us will unfortunately experience during our professional careers. Here, too, we encourage you to keep your instructors informed, but we will first ask you to try to resolve the issue yourself. If that doesn't improve the situation, please reach out to one of the instructors and we will help.

ASSIGNMENT SCHEDULE

Assignment	Author	Points	Due Date
Reading Responses (10)	Individual	(10*1.5) 15	All semester
Class Participation includes 3 components: - <i>Attendance</i> (total of 6 points: you need to be present for 12 out of 14 classes for full credit, each class counts for 0.5 pts) - <i>Participating in class discussions</i>, including with guest speakers (10 points: 5 points for mid-term assessment; 5 points for end-of-semester assessment) - <i>Group contribution/professionalism</i> based on peer and self evaluation surveys (10 points: 5 points for mid-term evaluation and 5 points for end of semester evaluation)	Individual	26	All semester
Black mirror in class workshop	Group	1	during class, week 2 (January 14)
Collaboration plan for online community study	First Group	1	January 14
Project management plan for online community study	First Group	0.5	January 21
Online community study proposal	First Group	1	January 21
Online community study paper	First Group	15	February 18
Online community study presentation	First Group	5	February 18
Self and peer evaluation for online community study assignment	First Group	-0.5 if not submitted	February 18 (same date as the assignments are due at 11:59 PM)
Final project study proposal	Second Group	1	February 25
Collaboration plan for final project	Second Group	1	February 25
Project management plan for final project	Second Group	0.5	February 25
Final design report or research paper	Second Group	27	April 15

Slides/presentation for final design or research paper	Second Group	5.5	April 15
Self and peer evaluation for final research/design project	Second Group	-0.5 if not submitted	April 15 (same date as the assignments are due at 11:59 PM)

Total: 100 points

Note: for all team assignments, you are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

You will fill out self and peer evaluation forms twice during the semester. This is in place to support your accountability to each other. You will not earn points for submitting these, but will lose 0.5 if you do not submit them on time. We will also use these insights and your contribution statements to inform *part* of your class participation grades. Obviously, if a student does not contribute to their group work appropriately, their grades on the associated assignments will also suffer in addition to their participation grade.

Grading

You should do good work in this class because you care about the project you pick and because you want to learn how to design interactive systems. That said, we adhere to university policy and use grades, so here is how grades will work in this class:

- **Class participation (26 points)**
 - Attendance (6 points total, ~0.46 points for each lecture/lab)
 - Note: Name tags will be available for every class. Please make sure to collect your name tags to register your attendance. The name tags which are not collected will not receive points for attendance. While there are 14 class sessions, you can still earn full credit (6 points) if you miss one session.
 - If you miss a class due to an illness or emergency, please inform the GSI of your situation and the teaching team will provide as much support and flexibility for you to complete the course. Read more in the [Missing Class Due to Illness or Emergency section below](#).
 - Participating in class discussions, Q&As (10 points)
 - Note: based on your active and meaningful participation in discussions, you'll receive a mid-term assessment (5pt) and an end-of-semester assessment (5pt)
 - [Please see the rubric in the assignment section below](#).
 - Group contribution/professionalism work (10 points: 5 points for each group project)
 - Note: you will assess your group mates twice throughout the semester for community analysis study and design/research assignment. How you are assessed by your teammates for your collaboration and contribution to work as well as professionalism factors into this grade. You will lose points if you do not submit the self and peer-evaluation forms.
 - If the comments from you and/or your peers in this form (or other formats) indicate that you have not contributed your fair share of work and/or have not been responsive/professional/respectful in your collaborative work together, the grades associated with relevant team assignments would *also* be impacted. That is, to

ensure fairness, your individual grade will not be the same as what your team's assignment's grade is.

- **Annotated readings** (15 points possible, 1.5 points for each submission)
 - Note: there are 10 total reading responses, you need to complete all 10 to get full credit
- Black Mirror assignment: (1 point: this will be an in-class workshop)
- Collaboration plan for online community study (1 point during class, see rubric)
- Project management plan for online community study paper (0.5 point, see rubric)
- Online community study proposal (1 point, see rubric)
- **Online community study paper** (15 points, see rubric)
- **Online community study presentation** (5 points, see rubric)
- Final project study proposal (1 point, see rubric)
- Collaboration plan for final project (1 point during class, see rubric)
- Project management plan for final project (0.5 point during class, see rubric)
- Final design report or research paper (27 points, see rubric)
- **Final Design or research presentation** (6 points, see rubric)

Assignment	Assignment type	Points	Details
Class Participation (26 points)	Attendance	6	~0.46 points per lecture/class (14 total) You get full credit even if one class session is missed. Note: Name tags will be available for every class. Please make sure to collect your name tags to register your attendance. The name tags which are not collected will not receive points for attendance. While there are 14 classes, you can still earn full credit (6 points) if you miss up to one class. If you miss a class due to an illness or emergency, please inform the GSI of your situation and the teaching team will provide as much support and flexibility for you to complete the course. Read more in the Missing Class Due to Illness or Emergency section below. Read more here.
	Class Discussions/Guest Speaker Q&A	10	5 points mid-term assessment, 5 points end-of-semester assessment. Based on active, meaningful

			participation Read more here
	Group Contribution/Professionalism	10	5 points per group project; based on peer/self evaluations. Note: You will assess your group mates twice throughout the semester for community analysis study and design/research assignment. How you are assessed by your teammates for your collaboration and contribution to work as well as professionalism factors into this grade. You will lose points if you do not submit the self and peer-evaluation forms. If the comments from you and/or your peers in this form (or other formats) indicate that you have not contributed your fair share of work and/or have not been responsive/professional/respectful in your collaborative work together, the grades associated with relevant team assignments would <i>also</i> be impacted. That is, to ensure fairness, your individual grade will not be the same as what your team's assignment's grade is. Read more here
Reading Responses	Reading Responses	15	1.5 points per submission; 10 total reading responses required for full credit. Read more here
Other Individual Assignments	Black Mirror Assignment	1	In-class workshop, usually scheduled for Week 2
Online Community Study (22.5 points) Read more here	Collaboration Plan	1	During class; see rubric
	Project Management Plan	0.5	See rubric

	Study Proposal	1	See rubric
	Study Paper	15	See rubric
	Study Presentation	5	See rubric
Final Project (35.5 points) Read more here	Study Proposal	1	See rubric
	Collaboration Plan	1	During class; see rubric
	Project Management Plan	0.5	During class; see rubric
	Final Design Report or Research Paper	27	Design track rubric Research track rubric
	Final Design or Research Presentation	6	Design track rubric Research track rubric

TOTAL: 100 points possible

Final grades will be recorded as letter grades using the following scale:

A+	99 - 100
A	93 - 98
A-	90 - 92
B+	87 - 89
B	83 - 86
B-	80 - 82
C+	77 - 79
C	73 - 76
C-	70 - 72
D+	67 - 69
D	63 - 66
D-	60 - 62
E	< 60

Late Policy

- Many of our classroom activities involve discussions, conversations, and reflections. For this reason, it is important that you finish your assignments on time and come to class prepared to discuss them when relevant.

- Attendance is taken in the beginning of the class, within the first 15 minutes of class, by the collection of non-picked-up name cards. an hour of class. Your attendance will not be counted if you arrive late, after 1:30 pm.
- You cannot “make up” for the attendance you miss. If 1) you have an excused absence that prohibited your participation and 2) you let us know *prior* to class, we may be able to offer you an alternative, but there is no guarantee.
- Any assignment submitted after the exact due date and time (as indicated by the Canvas timestamp) will be assessed a penalty of 5% for each 24-hour period after the time it is due. In some cases, extensions or adjustments may be granted if possible. Students must communicate with the instructional team **before** the deadline, unless that is not possible.
- Exceptions to the rules above will be made at the discretion of the instructor.

Grade Discrepancies

Students are responsible for viewing their grades in Canvas and informing the instructor of any discrepancies **within seven days** (after seven days, no adjustments will be made to grades). Students must keep copies of any work submitted until final grades are submitted. No petitions for grade adjustments will be considered after **2:30 pm EST, April 10, 2025** -- after this date, the only basis for changing your grade will be to correct instructor errors in recording or calculating your grades, no regrading will be done after this point.

Re-grading Policy

For project-based and other assignments, if you feel that the merit of your work on any assignment has not been fully recognized, you may choose to submit the assignment for **re-grading within seven days** after grades are released for that assignment. **To submit work for a re-grade**, you must explain in an email to the GSI why you feel your work deserves re-grading. You should provide details and point to specifics in the assignment that you feel merit a higher grade. One of three outcomes is possible: your grade may be raised, it may remain the same, or it may be lowered. The re-grade is final, even if it is lower than the original grade.

All members of your team must be in agreement to resubmit, and it is your responsibility to achieve that consensus.

Extra Credit

Extra credit assignments may be assigned throughout the semester at the instructor’s discretion. Students are responsible for checking that Canvas has correctly registered their participation and will have one week after extra credit grades are uploaded to inform the instructor about any problems (after this, scores will not be adjusted). Regardless of how many extra credit opportunities are offered, students can receive a maximum of 3 points in extra credit during the semester. Extra credit opportunities may include attending and writing a short reflection about talks or lectures - these should be uploaded to Canvas within one week of the event.

If you see an announcement about a relevant event (e.g., free talks, lectures, workshops, or films) on campus or online, please let your instructors know and we will announce to the class if it is relevant. It should be connected to the topic of online communities or online social interaction in some way.

If students complete more than 10 full-credit reading responses, one will count as one point (not 1.5) of “extra credit.”

These reflections should follow similar guidelines as your regular required reading reflection papers. They should be *true* reflections, not summaries. They will be similarly graded. We may ask you to share your reading response with the class so that the rest of the class, including the instructional team, can also learn from it. The latest date to submit these is 2:30 pm EST, April 10, 2026 to ensure that we have enough time for grading them before the final class.

Attendance, Class Participation, and Recording Classes

Your class participation grades rely on you being in class. We will do individual and group activities in class each week. **If you are absent, you are responsible for finding out what you missed in class by referring to the syllabus, your classmates, and/or watching the lecture. Additionally, you are responsible for communicating with your team about how you will catch up on your project work.**

This lecture time will be run as a seminar, meaning each student is expected to be present and engaged (not just “there”) and to contribute to class discussions in meaningful ways. While we do not want to encourage talk just for the sake of talk, we do ask that every student come to class prepared (having completed and thought about the readings) and ready to engage. We strongly encourage students to apply course readings and ideas to their own lives and use of social media, and to share these insights with the class.

Class will be held in person. There is no remote/hybrid option. Class participation includes attending class and participating in class discussion as well as professional, respectful conduct (e.g., not speaking with each other when a classmate is presenting or asking a question, repeatedly arriving late to the class or leaving early, doing non-class-related activities while in class, disrupting the class). If you are not present in the classroom or you are present but are mentally absent, you will not be able to participate in a meaningful way. Either form of absence will be reflected in your participation grade. **Your participation grade reflects your presence and attention practices as well as your conduct within the context of the course, along with your contributions to the intellectual climate of the classroom.**

On coming to class late or leaving early:

When students come to class late or leave early, it can disrupt the flow of a lecture or discussion, distract the instructor and students, and hinder learning. We expect that you are on time to the class, and stay until the end.

Unjustified late arrivals or leaving early will impact your participation grade. Additionally, if you arrive while we are doing an in-class activity, you may not be able to partake in the activity or gain full points for it. If you have a valid reason for being late once or twice, please let us know *in advance*.

If you are not able to attend class synchronously, you will need to watch the Lecture Capture video of the lecture afterwards. If you are regularly not in class and/or class, your class participation grade will significantly suffer because you are not able to meaningfully participate in class discussions.

On the first day of class, we will provide you with a piece of paper to make a name card that is legible to read from a distance. Please bring this (or your own replacement) to each class.

We may pass around a sheet of paper on random days to note class presence.

Missing Class Due to Illness or Emergency

If you are sick, including with any symptoms of Covid, flu, or any other viral illness please DO NOT COME to the class. Please contact us as soon as you know you are sick and we will take it from there.

UMSI recognizes the extreme circumstances surrounding this academic term. We strive to provide an inclusive environment and to support the academic success of all students. If you experience illness or emergency during the term, please inform the GSI **before** class that you cannot participate in class. If you cannot participate due to illness or emergency, the instructor will provide as much support and flexibility as possible for you to complete the course.

If you have **ongoing** physical or mental accommodation needs, you can contact the Services for Students with Disabilities Office (734-763-3000; ssd.umich.edu/). If you will be out for an extended period, or if you need additional academic support, please contact your academic advising team.

Overall, if you are struggling, it is best to let us know sooner rather than later so we can find ways to best support you.

Tools

We/your teams may use the following tools throughout the course for various activities:

- Miro
- Zoom
- Google docs/slides
- Software for prototyping and wireframing for those doing the design track for the final assignment (your choice - many students use Figma or Adobe XD for digital prototyping, and Balsamiq for wireframing).

We also recommend that you consider using technology for team collaboration. You can consider tools such as Slack, Google docs/slides, or Trello to help you manage your progress and collaborative activities. **It is up to you what tools you use to collaborate, and we *strongly* encourage you to have a conversation with your teammates about this as soon as your teams are decided and set expectations and goals.**

Communication with the Instruction Team

Please use “[SI 529]” at the start of the subject header in emails you send to instructors and/or the GSI.

Your first point of contact for most grading/assignment-related issues will be the GSI, [Name] <email id>

For any other course-related issues (e.g., a reading is not available; you have questions about course content; you have a question about an upcoming assignment) please email both instructor and the GSI. If you are not sure whom to contact and it is a time-sensitive issue, you can email both and one of us will respond.

If there are issues you would like to discuss with one or both of the instructors, please contact them directly. While we will do our best to respond to your inquiries as soon as possible, you can expect that it may take us up to 2 business days to respond to your emails. Questions that require discussions lengthier than a short (5 minutes or less) response will be better addressed in office hours. If you need a response by a certain time, please make sure to plan accordingly.

Anonymous Feedback Form: This can be used to give feedback to the instructional team throughout the semester. Please feel free to fill it out at any time! [Click here.](#)

Some Guidelines for Dialogue within the Classroom

We will do our best to:

1. **Maintain confidentiality.** We want to create an atmosphere for open, honest exchange.

2. **Commit to learning from each other.** We will listen to each other and not talk at each other. We acknowledge differences among us in backgrounds, skills, interests, identities and values. We realize that it is these very differences that will increase our awareness and understanding through this process.
 3. **Not demean, devalue, or “put down” people for their experiences,** lack of experiences, or difference in interpretation of those experiences.
 4. **Trust that people are always doing the best they can.** We will give each other the benefit of the doubt. We will assume we are all trying our hardest and that our intentions are good even when the impact is not.
 5. **Challenge the idea and not the person.** If we wish to challenge something that has been said, we will challenge the idea or the practice referred to, not the individual sharing this idea or practice.
 6. **Speak our discomfort.** If something is bothering us, we will share this with the group. Often our emotional reactions to this process offer the most valuable learning opportunities.
 7. **Step Up, Step Back.** We will be mindful of taking up much more space than others. On the same note, empower ourselves to speak up when others are dominating the conversation.
 8. **Not to freeze people in time.** We are all works in progress. We will be willing to change and make space for others to do so. Therefore we will not assume that one comment or one opinion made at one time captures the whole of a person's character.
- *The Program on Intergroup Relations, University of Michigan, 2012*

Accessible Teaching and Learning Environment

We know that courses at UM and UMSI can be demanding, but that is because we want you to be able to learn, explore, and reach your full potential. We aim to create an accessible environment for teaching and learning in my classroom. Each of us comes to class with different assumptions, values, and opinions. Rather than being in the way, however, I see such differences as valuable starting points for building the community I hope we build over the course of the semester.

If you find that any aspect of the course creates a barrier to you achieving your learning goals and objectives, please reach out to us and we can discuss how we can adjust to meet your needs. You can reach us via email or student hours.

We also want to let you know about the following resources that might help you find the School of Information, and the University at large, more accommodating:

- UMSI Office of Academic and Student Affairs (OASA): 333 Maynard (5th floor, Collegian building, which is located next to the Maynard entrance to Nichols Arcade)
- Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS): (734) 764-8312
- Psychiatric Emergency Services (U of M Hospital): (734) 996-4747
- Sexual Assault Prevention and Awareness Center (SAPAC) 24-Hour Crisis Line: (734) 936-3333
- Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD): (734) 763-3000
- Sweetland Center for Writing: <https://lsa.umich.edu/sweetland/undergraduates.html>

If you ever need, or want, assistance navigating and making use of these resources, please don't hesitate to ask either of the instructors.

We recognize the unique needs of Student Caregivers. If you are a pregnant, parenting student, or primarily responsible for providing care for a loved one or family member, and you are in need of any accommodations, please let us know at your earliest convenience so we can discuss accommodations. Additionally, the [University of Michigan CEW+](https://umich.edu/cew) and mcasp.org has information and resources available to support you.

If you need to miss class due to observing a religious holiday, please contact us at least one week in advance by email to discuss any make-up assignments.

Disability Statement

The University of Michigan recognizes disability as an integral part of diversity and is committed to creating an inclusive and equitable educational environment for students with disabilities. Students who are experiencing a disability-related barrier should contact [Services for Students with Disabilities](https://ssd.umich.edu/) (<https://ssd.umich.edu/>; 734-763-3000 or ssdoffice@umich.edu). For students who are connected with SSD, accommodation requests can be made in Accommodate. If you have any questions or concerns please contact your SSD Coordinator or visit SSD's Current Student webpage. SSD considers aspects of the course design, course learning objects and the individual academic and course barriers experienced by the student. Further conversation with SSD, instructors, and the student may be warranted to ensure an accessible course experience. The instructional team will treat any information that you provide in as confidential a manner as possible.

We want to be able to support you and your learning. We would be able to do so best if we know about what you need at the **beginning of the semester**. Please don't hesitate to reach out so we can discuss how to best support you.

Student Mental Health and Wellbeing

Students may experience stressors that can impact both their academic experience and their personal well-being. These may include academic pressure and challenges associated with relationships, mental health, alcohol or other drugs, identities, finances, etc.

If you are experiencing concerns, seeking help is a courageous thing to do for yourself and those who care about you. If the source of your stressors is academic, please contact me so that we can find solutions together. For personal concerns, U-M offers the following resources:

- [Counseling and Psychological Services \(CAPS\)](#) - confidential; 734-764-8312; for after-hours urgent support, call and press 0; counseling, workshops, groups and more. Ashley Ewearitt, a CAPS counselor is embedded in UMSI, information about how to schedule an appointment with her can be found [here](#).
- [Dean of Students Office](#) - 734-764-7420; provides support services to students and manages critical incidents impacting students and the campus community
- [Ginsberg Center for Community Service Learning](#) - 734-763-3548; opportunities to engage as learners and leaders to create a better community and world
- [Maize and Blue Cupboard \(MBC\)](#) - 734-936-2794; Food pantry with groceries, kitchen and cooking supplies, personal and household items, and support
- [Multi-ethnic Student Affairs \(MESA\)](#) - 734-763-9044; diversity and social justice through the lens of race and ethnicity
- [Office of Student Conflict Resolution](#) - 734-936-6308; offers multiple pathways for resolving conflict
- [Office of the Ombuds](#) - 734-763-3545; students can raise questions and concerns about the functioning of the university.
- [Services for Students with Disabilities \(SSD\)](#) - 734-763-3000; accommodations and access to students with disabilities
- [SilverCloud](#) - Students may also use an online, self-guided, interactive mental health resource that provides cognitive behavioral interventions.

- [Sexual Assault Prevention and Awareness Center \(SAPAC\)](#) - confidential; 734-764-7771 or 24-hour crisis line 734-936-3333; addresses sexual assault, intimate partner violence, sexual harassment, and stalking
- [Spectrum Center](#) - 734-763-4186; support services for LGBTQ+ students
- [Trotter Multicultural Center](#) - 734-763-3670; intercultural engagement and inclusive leadership education initiatives
- [University Health Service \(UHS\)](#) - 734-764-8320; clinical services include nurse advice by phone, day or night
- [Well-being for U-M Students website](#) - searchable list of many more campus resources
- [Wolverine Wellness](#) - 734-763-1320; provides Wellness Coaching, Collegiate Recovery Program, and much more

Academic Integrity

Collaboration

UMSI strongly encourages collaboration while working on some assignments, such as homework problems and interpreting reading assignments as a general practice. Active learning is effective. Collaboration with other students in the course will be especially valuable in summarizing the reading materials and picking out the key concepts. You must, however, write your homework submission on your own, in your own words, before turning it in. If you worked with someone on the homework before writing it, you must list any and all collaborators on your written submission. Each course and each instructor may place restrictions on collaboration for any or all assignments. Read the instructions carefully and request clarification about collaboration when in doubt. Collaboration is almost always forbidden for take-home and in class exams.

Additionally, adding the names of classmates on work they have not contributed to, adding absent students' names for them to sheets/in-class activities, and similar behavior represent academic dishonesty and are not acceptable.

Plagiarism

All written submissions must be your own, original work. Original work for narrative questions is not mere paraphrasing of someone else's completed answer: you must not share written answers with each other at all. At most, you should be working from notes you took while participating in a study session. Largely duplicate copies of the same assignment will receive an equal division of the total point score from the one piece of work.

You may incorporate selected excerpts, statements or phrases from publications by other authors, but they must be clearly marked as quotations and must be attributed. If you build on the ideas of prior authors, you must cite their work. You may obtain copy editing assistance, and you may discuss your ideas with others, but all substantive writing and ideas must be your own, or be explicitly attributed to another. See the (Doctoral, MSI, BSI) student handbooks available on the UMSI intranet for the definition of plagiarism, resources to help you avoid it, and the consequences for intentional or unintentional plagiarism.

Use of Generative AI

Emerging generative AI tools can be helpful in specific contexts. You can use these tools as a guide for course activities and assignments unless stated otherwise. They can be used as a reference, spell-check, and inspiration for assignments, provided it enhances your understanding and creativity without replacing your original work. If you do use generative AI, you must explicitly acknowledge and cite both your prompts and the outputs.

Exercise caution, as generative AI may produce incorrect or made up text, citations, and artifacts, often in ways that are difficult to detect. You are fully responsible for any content derived from AI outputs. In many cases, relying on your own knowledge and expertise may be more effective than using AI tools. Reflect on the value of your contributions and consider what it means if your work mirrors the average output of an AI tool.

Individual Assignments

Participating in class discussions [10% of Final Grade]

Based on your **active, meaningful, respectful, and professional** participation in class, you'll receive a mid-term assessment and an end-of-semester assessment for 5 pts each, a total of 10 pts. This will be a measure of both contribution quantity and quality. Participation in class can include:

- Actively engaging during lectures by participating in class discussions.
- Attending office hours to share your thoughts, ask questions, and engage in 1:1 interactions with instructors and GSIs.
- Participating in lecture activities, such as contributing to Canvas discussions and taking part in class exercises.
- Asking insightful questions and contributing to discussions with guest speakers.

You can participate in whichever medium feels most comfortable to you—whether that's speaking in class or sharing your thoughts through Canvas posts. Note that doing the readings and other preparation work is necessary for contributing to classroom conversations in a way that is productive and moves the discussion forward, not backward. In other words, please do not say something just to "say something" – you need to contribute to the discussion in a meaningful way in order to receive full credit for this portion of the grade. You can do so in class and/or post about current events pertaining to online communities in the [Canvas discussion section](#). This should be a reflective commentary from you, similar to how you are expected to participate in class discussions (e.g., just posting a link with a sentence does not count). Please note that if we have time, sometimes we may invite you to share what you have read/written on Canvas during the class time so that we can all have a discussion about the interesting things you find and reflect on.

Below you can see what constitutes full and 0 participation points. Range of points is 0-10.

Mid-term Rubric

Students actively participate in discussions and activities in lectures and labs (e.g., when asked about points in the readings speaks, asks questions, posts on Canvas, participates in in-class activities meaningfully), students are respectful and professional in class	5 pts
While students are present, they sometimes contribute to class by offering ideas and asking questions, they do not always participate in in-class activities, they sometimes do not engage respectfully and professionally in class	1-4 pts
While students are present in class, they do not participate by offering ideas or asking questions, do not engage respectfully and professionally in class	0 pts

End-of-semester Rubric

Students actively participate in discussions and activities in lectures and classes (e.g., when asked about points in the readings speaks, asks questions, posts on canvas, participates in in-class activities meaningfully), students are respectful and professional in class	5pts
While students are present, they sometimes contribute to class by offering ideas and asking questions, they do not always participate in in-class activities, they sometimes do not engage respectfully and professionally in class	1-4 pts
While Students are present in class, they do not participate by offering ideas or asking questions, do not engage respectfully and professionally in class	0 pts

A note on in-class activities

During class, we may have activities designed to help you reflect on the readings and what we've covered. These activities will contribute to your participation grade ([as mentioned in the section above](#)). In-class activities will vary and may include group work assigned during class or sharing insights on the Canvas discussion board.

If you arrive while we are doing an in-class activity, you may not be able to partake in the activity or gain full points for it ([Please see the Attendance, Class Participation, and Recording Classes section of the syllabus](#)) as it may be disruptive to the class, students may already be in teams, activity time may be ending, etc.

If you are unable to participate in your in-class activity for a valid reason (e.g., emergency, being sick) and you have let us know in advance (when possible), we will do our best to support you and provide alternative options that can count towards your participation grade. If this becomes relevant to you, please 1) email the GSI with the reason for not being able to partake in the activity in class (*prior to the class*) and 2) ask if there is an alternative available for you. If you frequently are not able to participate in class activities, you would need to consult with Academic Advising. We will not be able to offer alternatives for in-class activities when there is no valid justification for not doing them in class.

Guest Lecture Questions

On some weeks, a guest will join us in class in-person or via Zoom for Q&A on that week's topic; some of these guests will be authors of papers we have read in class. You are responsible for submitting one or two questions (on Canvas) related to their work by 5:00 PM the day before they join us in class. I will choose some student questions each time, and will invite you to ask the guest your question.

Question assignment guidance and guidelines:

- Please submit one to two questions for each guest speaker
- Before submitting your question, please read the guest speaker's paper (they are an author of an assigned reading) and look at the speaker's online profile to ensure you are addressing the correct person.
- Ask an appropriate, thoughtful question based on the paper of theirs that you read **that is not answered by the text**
- Please do not ask basic questions about the paper (such as the publication date) or personal questions about our guest

Questions that do not follow these guidelines will either not earn credit or earn half credit.

Guest Q& A Questions Rubric

Student asked one or two appropriate and thoughtful question(s) that engaged with and expanded on the speaker's writing (which we read for class).	1 pts
Student asked one or two question(s) that were appropriate, but the questions did not expand on the reading or was already answered in the text.	0.5 pts
Student asked one or two questions that were not appropriate (i.e. personal question or irrelevant to the paper we read).	0 pts

Group participation [10% of final grade]

A large part of your grade in this class will be based on your ability to work collaboratively in a group. To assess your level of participation and professionalism within your group, after completing the Online Community Study and Final Research/Design project, respectively, you will be asked to fill out a self-assessment of your own performance in the group work and an assessment of the peers' work in your group. Based on these assessments the instructional team will issue group participation grades at the middle and end of the term.

Mid-term Group Participation Rubric

Student actively participated in the planning and execution of the online community study, including but not limited to regularly showing up at group meetings, actively adding to group planning and research processes, and taking on an equitable amount of work in writing the final report and/or creating the slides for the final presentation.	5 pts
While the student was present for team meetings or made some contributions to the planning and execution of the project, they did notably or significantly less work than their peers and sometimes did not engage with their peers in a respectful or professional manner.	1-4 pts
Student did not meaningfully contribute to the group project and did not engage respectfully and professionally with their peers.	0 pts

End-of-semester Group Participation Rubric

Student actively participated in the planning and execution of the final project, including but not limited to regularly showing up at group meetings, actively adding to group planning and research process, and taking on an equitable amount of work in writing the final report and/or creating slides.	5pts
While the student was present for team meetings or made some contribution to the planning and execution of the project, they did notably or significantly less work than their peers and sometimes did not engage with their peers in a respectful or professional manner.	1-4 pts
Student did not meaningfully contribute to the group project and did not engage respectfully and professionally with their peers.	0 pts

READINGS

All readings will be available on the Canvas website for this class, unless they are only available online, in which case a URL will be provided. (Note that readings may change; any changes will be announced via Canvas).

If you cannot access a reading for some reason, please let all instructors know ASAP via email so we can correct the problem for the entire class.

Please note: **everyone in the class is expected to come to class having read the required readings for that class.** If you do not do the required readings, your understanding of the course material will suffer, as will your grade and the classroom discussions. All readings and reading responses are due at the beginning of the lecture.

Please see the [reading reflections](#) in the Assignments section of the syllabus for details and instructions.

Reading responses: Choose One Option Each Week [15% of Final Grade]

Each week, you will submit a reading reflection on Canvas based on that week's assigned readings and prompt. These reflections are an important part of the course: they help you synthesize key ideas from the readings, apply course concepts to real-world examples, and prepare for class discussion and project work.

You may choose between two formats each week: a traditional written reflection where you will write 1-2 paragraphs in response to a prompt or a creative visual response. Regardless of format, your submission must demonstrate that you have read and engaged with **each** of the assigned readings.

Option 1: Traditional Reading Reflection (Written Response)

Write a **1–2 paragraph** (or up to 1 single-spaced page) reflection for the readings assigned that day. Your response **must reference all assigned readings** (not including “recommended” ones, though you're encouraged to explore those too) for the week. If you focus on one, briefly acknowledge the others. Your goal is not to summarize the readings but to **reflect thoughtfully and analytically**. We are looking for **insight**, not a recap or summary. You are encouraged to use **scholarly language** and reference relevant **concepts, theories, or frameworks** discussed in class. Please use **APA format** for any citations.

These should be at least 2 paragraphs single space, and up to 1 page **single space**. Your response should reflect on the readings and discuss points you found particularly interesting. **What you don't want your reflection to be is just a summary or reiteration of the readings.** Please *reflect* on your readings. Tell us what they mean. Relate readings to one another, or to online sites or your own experiences. We are looking for insight. You are strongly encouraged to connect the readings to your online community project(s), as relevant.

Responses that appear to be AI-generated, are only a summary of the readings or lack originality, depth, or personal engagement will be marked down.

Weekly Prompts

Some weeks, you'll receive a prompt on Canvas to help guide your reflection. Prompts will typically ask you to relate the readings to real-world experiences or communities. Examples include:

- How do the readings connect to a specific online community you're part of or have observed?
- What issues or themes stood out in this week's readings, and why do they matter?
- [Example for Week 2] How is the Belmont Report important to online communities today? What might be missing or outdated?

While writing your reflection, you are encouraged to:

- Include quotes or examples from the readings
- Reflect on your own online experiences
- **Connect the readings to what you are observing in your online community study**
- Ask questions or raise ideas for class discussion

Although you may write about shortcomings of the reading, you are **discouraged** from doing so. It is easy to tear pretty much anything apart, and is not necessarily a productive exercise. Even if you mainly disagree with a reading, the more interesting question to ask yourself is: what about this was valuable? So reflections that their only points are statements like “they could have done this other study but they did not, or they did not report on this other issue” or “their sample size was small” will not be considered very insightful.

There are 10 total weeks of opportunities to write reading reflections, but to give you some flexibility, you only need to turn in 9 reading reflections. You are, however, responsible for doing the readings even on weeks you don’t turn in reading responses.

- Full credit is 1.5 points for each reading response. You will get full credit if it is clear that you read the readings and you engaged with them meaningfully and specifically in your response, your writing is professional and free of errors, and your references cited properly and using the APA format.
- You will get a grade between 0.25-1.5 if you wrote something, but it’s not clear if you actually did the readings or not (e.g., lack of specifics and/or meaningful engagement), if you merely provide a summary without much reflection, or if you do not cite your sources properly. Where on this continuum your grade falls will depend on the quality of your submission.

Reading reflections may not be turned in late, unless there is a reasonable excuse that you let us know **before the assignment is due**. The reason for this is that readings are a foundational part of this graduate class’s experience.

Option 2: Creative Visual Response (Fun option)

Create and post a meme, comic, or image of some sort that relates to the article in a funny or unique way. It’s up to you to be creative and/or clever in whatever way you choose. It should be clear that you have done the readings and understand them. **Since each class has multiple readings, you must create an image/meme/comic for each one.** We may share these in class and discuss them.

Team Assignments

Online Community Study Assignment [22.5% of final grade]

In teams, select one online community to study. You must have a set of research questions that motivate your choice.

Analyze the community in terms of principles and theories we have discussed in class. Specifically, and at least, analyze the community **in terms of Amy Jo Kim’s “[Nine Principles for Community Design](#)”** (one of your readings). How does the community address **each** of these issues? In what ways is the community successful? Is it meeting the needs of its members? Compare and contrast the community to other similar ones. In what ways could the community be better designed? How would you change it?

Your team will also conduct original research. Each team member will conduct **participant observation** in which you participate in your chosen online community for at least 5 hours. Past time spent on a site does **not** count toward hours. All team members must conduct participant observation. Take careful notes about your experience each time you do your observations.

You are not collecting other types of data (e.g., interviews, surveys, or direct quotes). **You are asked to simply observe and take notes** (you will need to submit your notes—see below). You can participate in these communities as you naturally would if you were not doing so for this project. But for the purpose of the project we ask that you do not interact with others on the site that you are observing. This is because if you engage in any way with others, you should signal that you are learning from this interaction for a course assignment. But in doing so you may receive some pushback, for good reason, if you are perceived to be formally studying a site and collecting user data (which is not what you are doing). To keep things simpler and safer, **you will only observe**.

This assignment consists of the following components:

Collaboration Plan for Online Community Study Assignment [1% of final grade]

In this assignment, due before the second class, you will work with your team to establish some common expectations for your teamwork using a template that will be available on Canvas.

You are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

Rubric

Work through the prompts as a team and submit your collaboration plan.	1 pts
Contribution statement	- 0.5 if not submitted

Online Community Study Assignment Project Management Plan [0.5% of final grade]

Develop a plan to complete your project. There will be work to do, and you need to distribute the work. It is crucial to develop a plan of who is responsible for which parts of your deliverable. Have open and direct communication with your group for an improved experience for all.

Submit a ½-page plan by Jan 21 that describes what you will achieve by Feb 18 and how you will divide the work between your team members. If your team doesn't meet its own goals and expectations, have a conversation with each other and see how you might overcome the challenges. If you run into problems, reach out to us as soon as possible.

You are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

Rubric

1/2-page plan for who is responsible for what over the next few weeks	0.5 pts
Contribution statement	- 0.5 if not submitted

Online Community Study Assignment Proposal [1% of final grade]

Submit a brief (½ to 1 page, in PDF format) problem statement by Jan 21 for the project your team would like to work on for the community study assignment. **We need to approve your proposal before you can proceed with your proposed study.** If you happen to want to change your site, you should get our approval again. But we strongly encourage you to think this through using the guidelines in the assignment description so that you won't need to. We want to make sure that you have a good reason to study the site you want to study and that you will be doing so responsibly and ethically.

You will brainstorm ideas as a team to determine what problem/online community you'd like to focus on. This assignment helps you learn how to articulate the problem space, and specify the constraints and opportunities that you will consider when carrying out research in online communities, in this case participant observation.

You are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

Tips for planning your proposal:

- Read the [online community study assignment](#) and tips about selecting a community.
- It's a good idea to choose a site that is successful. You'll learn more by thinking in detail about something that works than by tearing apart something that doesn't work. And it's much easier to do a thoughtful analysis of a successful site.
- Pick a site that you enjoy and can imagine yourself spending a lot of time on. You will be there a lot for your participant observation.
- If you cannot participate in a space ethically it means you should not propose to study it.
- Because this is a group project, all members of your team need to feel comfortable to participate in the site. Not everyone may be so excited about it, but everyone should feel safe and comfortable to participate.

Rubric

Statement describes the online community, provides a link to the community, and shares a good reason for studying it	0.5 pts
Statement describes how the team will carry out the study ethically and protect their own safety and wellbeing as well as the community members'	0.5 pts
Contribution statement	- 0.5 if not submitted

Online Community Study Assignment [15% of final grade]

For this paper, due on Feb 18, your group will select one online community to study and you must have a set of research questions that are motivating your choice. **Your choice must be approved by the instructors before you begin your analysis.**

Analyze the community in terms of principles and theories we have discussed in class. Specifically, and at least, analyze the community **in terms of Amy Jo Kim's "Nine Principles for Community Design"** (one of your readings). How does the community address **each** of these issues? In what ways is the community successful? Is it meeting the needs of its members? Compare and contrast the community to other similar ones. In what ways could the community be better designed? How would you change it?

In your paper, make sure to cite the course readings (and feel free to go beyond them) and include a **detailed bibliography in APA format**. This means, you need to cite your sources.

Your team will also conduct original research. Each team member will conduct **participant observation** in which you participate in your chosen online community for at least 5 hours. Past time spent on a site does **not** constitute part of those hours. All team members must do this. Take careful notes about your experience each time you do your observations.

You are **not** collecting other types of data (e.g., interviews, surveys, or direct quotes). **You are asked to simply observe and take notes** (you will need to submit your notes – see below). You can participate in these communities as you naturally would for when you are not doing so for this project. But for the purpose of the project we ask that you do not interact with others. This is because if you do engage in any way with others, you should signal that you are learning from this interaction for a course assignment. But in doing so you may receive some pushback, for good reason, if you are perceived to be formally studying a site and collecting user data (which is not what you are doing). So to keep things simpler and safer, **you will only observe**.

Some useful research tools are [Google Scholar](#) and the UM Library web databases.

What to Turn In

2000-3000 words per group. Appendices and references do not count towards the word limit. If you do need more space, please feel free to use it to tell your story well, but do not go above twice the noted word limit. Please use APA style to format your paper and its bibliography: You can find a sample format [here](#).

Introduction

Begin your paper with a short description of your site and its functionality. Briefly describe the audience. Describe the research questions that you were looking to address.

Related Work

Describe prior literature and other communities that motivated your research questions and that help us understand your results. Four peer-reviewed sources from the class syllabus (required or suggested readings) and three peer-reviewed sources from outside of class are required.

Methods

Describe how you did your research: How did you participate? Did your team members have different participation strategies? What worked and what did not work? Make sure to discuss how you ensured you ethically conducted this assignment.

Results

Present the findings that you discovered. These should be organized in a logical way and should address the research questions you started with. You may have learned other things you were not focusing on that are still relevant here—document those things as well. Identify key characteristics, behaviors, goals, and values of the community's users. Identify key insights relevant to the community. Elaborate with illustrative stories and quotes. You will be evaluated on your ability to turn your notes to insights/results that help you to better understand your site.

Conclusion

Recommend actions and future research. Do *not* leave this to the last minute. We expect to see careful and thoughtful ideas presented that are not obvious at first glance. If you could have come up with these conclusions without doing the research or taking the class, you haven't thought about it enough.

Contribution Statement

Please provide a brief and accurate description of who on the team did which parts of the assignment. You won't earn points for including a contribution statement, but you will lose 0.5 point if you do not include this in your submissions.

References

Please use APA style to format your paper and its bibliography. You won't get points for including a bibliography, but **you will lose points** if your work is not appropriately cited.

Appendix

As appendices, you should **submit each team member's research notes clearly noting what belongs to whom and including full names**. They do not need to be formatted or polished. If a team member does not have notes submitted, they will lose points.

You should NOT include identifiable information or direct posts from online communities you studied in your report or presentation. If you need to share data for the paper or presentation, you should use methods to anonymize the quotes (though paraphrasing), usernames, pictures, etc. You can also utilize a method called "[ethical fabrication](#)."

You will be graded on the following qualities:

- Quality of writing, synthesis, and argumentation.
- Attention to detail.
- Quality of field work and ethical considerations.
- Thoughtful engagement with course readings. Show us that you have done the readings and they have aided in your understanding of what you observed.
- Insight into research issues about the design of online communities.
- Spelling, grammar, narrative clarity.
- For the contribution statement, please provide a brief and accurate description of who on the team did which parts of the assignment.

Rubric

Introduction	2 pts
Related work	4 pts
Methods	3 pts
Results	5 pts
Conclusion	1 pts
Contribution statement	-0.5 if not submitted
**Overall Writing Clarity/Proofreading Papers should be written in full sentence form, avoiding passive voice as much as possible, with no typographical or other errors. References and appendices are in correct APA format.	Up to -5 pts for poorly written or errors

Online Community Study Assignment Slides and Presentation [5% of final grade]

Prepare and submit a slide deck that illustrates your community study due on Feb 18. If you use Google slides or other online collaborative tools, please do *not* submit a link. Export it as a powerpoint or PDF and submit that. The project slides will be shown on your laptop during the final presentations. You should design for 16:9 landscape Full HD (1920x1080p) widescreen resolution. The design and the layout of the slides is open for creativity. Your slide or slide deck should include the following:

- Your project's name
- The names of all contributing team members
- Main points from the required paper sections: introduction, related work, methods, results, conclusion, contribution statement slide
- You will NOT present the contribution statements for your slides and presentations, we just want to have it on a slide. You won't earn points for including a contribution statement, but you will lose 0.5 point if you do not include this in your submissions.

Not all team members need to talk as part of the presentation, but at least 2 team members should. You do not need to include every single detail that you have included in your paper in your presentation, but just the highlights and provide us with a takeaway.

Note: student presentations will be very short (**5-10 minutes**), so you will need to be very concise. **You should have a script and rehearse your presentation.** Because we have limited time, we will have to cut you off if you go over 10 minutes. If you do run out of time (which if you plan and practice you won't) points will be deducted for the parts in the rubric you didn't cover in your presentation.

Rubric

Introduction	1 pts
Related work, Methods	1 pts
Results	1 pts
Conclusion	1 pts
Layout of slide deck and narrative <i>[The presentation engages the audience with a clear structure and a balanced mix of visuals and content in the slide decks]</i>	1 pts
Contribution statement	-0.5 if not submitted

Final Project Assignment [35.5% of final grade]

Collaboration Plan for Final Research/Design Track [1% of final grade]

In this assignment due Feb 25, you will work with your team to establish some common expectations for your teamwork using a template that will be available on Canvas.

You are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

Rubric

Work through the prompts as a team and submit your collaboration plan.	1 pts
Contribution statement	- 0.5 if not submitted

Project Management Plan for Final Research/Design Project [0.5% of final grade]

Develop a plan to complete your project. There will be work to do, and you need to distribute the work. It is crucial to develop a plan of who is responsible for which parts of your deliverable. Have open and direct communication with your group for an improved experience for all.

Submit a ½-page plan by Feb 25 that describes what you will achieve by Apr 15 and how you will divide the work between your team members. If your team doesn't meet its own goals and expectations, have a conversation with each other and see how you might overcome the challenges. If you run into problems, reach out to us as soon as possible.

You are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

Rubric

1/2-page plan for who is responsible for what over the next few weeks	0.5 pts
Contribution statement	- 0.5 if not submitted

Final Research/Design Project Proposal [1% of final grade]

Submit a brief (½ to 1 page, in PDF format) problem statement by Feb 25 for the project your team would like to work on for the final project. You will brainstorm ideas as a team starting during class in week 8, but **you should plan on spending time outside of class to decide on your projects.**

You are required to submit a brief contribution statement report. You do not get points for doing so, but will lose 0.5 point for not doing so.

Rubric

Statement describes the design or research project and shares good reasons for doing the project (i.e., why/how does this project matter to the world of research or design, and to your learning)	1 pts
Contribution statement	- 0.5 if not submitted

Design Track's Final Assignment Paper [27% of final grade]

Overview

For this assignment, due on Apr 15, you will be asked to design an online community, one that you could potentially create. The topic or focus of the online community can be anything you choose, but the goal is

to create a site that people would actually use. You'll need to describe both the social and technical features of the site, including how they interact to produce the processes you are trying to encourage.

To complement your assigned reading material and to help you succeed in this assignment, we recommend the book "Building Successful Online Communities: Evidence-Based Social Design" By Paul Resnick, Robert E. Kraut, and Sara Kiesler. The book is [available](#) as an e-book at the UM library. It is a very readable and useful book!

Your imagined audience for this document is an investor whom you are trying to convince to give you seed funding. With that in mind, you'll need to make arguments about how there is a real need for this community, how your sociotechnical design will work, and how your design will be effective. To do that, use evidence from our readings, research on your own from both academic and reputable business press arguments (e.g., Gartner, NYTimes -- random websites or Wikipedia **do not count**. If you are unsure about the credibility of a source, please ask us or the library staff!), the recommended book above, and provide examples from other online communities, especially those you are using as inspiration or which represent your competition.

This should **not** look like a double-spaced, typical academic paper (that said, please use APA style to format your report and its bibliography where relevant: You can find a sample format [here](#).)

You should use design elements and formatting to make it look interesting (ProTip: there are templates in Word to make that easy). Your description should include wireframes, screenshots, or other visual elements to demonstrate how these tools will work, though hand drawn work is fine. Imagine that the investor type is busy, and they are not going to slog through an uninteresting prospectus. With that in mind, think about how to call out information and images that will support your arguments. Your document should be about ten pages long (single-spaced), not including the cover page. Now that you know the general information regarding this assignment, please read on for the required organization of what you will include in your reports.

You will hand in:

1. Elevator Pitch
2. Design
3. Mockup
4. User Scenario(s)
5. Competitive Analysis
6. Ethical reflections
7. References and appendices (if applicable)
8. Contribution statement

1. Elevator Pitch

Provide a brief overview of your new site, who it is for, and how it will be sustained financially. Your business model could be either for-profit or nonprofit. You do not need a financial statement, just a written description of the business model for your community.

Some sites will have more than one target audience. If so, describe each audience, and how the site will contribute different things for each group.

This is not an exercise in science fiction-- please make your design technically realizable. Do not include features that require major technological advances to achieve. It's acceptable to describe a feature that would require such an advance only if you also provide a currently practical alternative.

2. Design

Discuss the design of your online community, answering some of the topics listed below. You can mention community features, norms, identity, participation, moderation, success metrics, and anything else that is important to understand how the community would function.

Potential questions this section could answer include (note that you don't need to answer all of these questions, but these are suggested topics to cover):

1. What is the topic or focus of the community?
2. How will you attract members? How will you retain them? How will you grow the community?
3. What are the identity rules you are going to enact?
4. What types of user roles will you encourage?
5. What are the types of participation you'll ask of users?
6. How will you encourage participation and contribution?
7. What moderation system will you use, if any? Why?
8. What are some metrics you will use to gauge the success of the community?

3. Mockups

Create digital mockups depicting your design using a tool of your choice. You should propose one overall app or site (i.e., the same branding across all mockups), but with different pages within the app or site (e.g., a profile page, a discussion page, etc). **Teams should submit at least 2 screens per team member** (so, at least 6 total screens for a group of 3 and 8 total screens for a group of 4).

You can choose which designs to depict in your main document and add the rest to the appendices with names of who created each design. You should choose mockups that are reasonably distinct from one another (do not create only minor variants of the same design). These do not need to be comprehensive or sequential (you do not need to mockup all possible screens for your design) and you do not need expert graphic design skills to do this (constructing in Powerpoint is acceptable). Your designs should be somewhere between a low and medium-fidelity prototype: in other words, they should have major components of the design, interface details (buttons, etc.), images, some amount of color, and some amount of text. They do **not** need to have sophisticated color schemes or branding and they do not need to be interactive. You do not need to design your own icons or other images--using creative commons licensed images in your design is fine and recommended.

You can include mockups in their own section, or weave them throughout your document to emphasize certain points (i.e., in the Design section). Provide captions (brief descriptions) of each mockup you submit.

4. User Scenario(s)

Write a fictional story of someone using your site. Scenarios describe how someone might come to your online community, why, and what they would do there. Why do they come there, and what do they do when they are there? If you have more than one target audience, write a scenario for each.

Submit 2 scenarios for your site's mockup. Scenarios should be about 100 words each.

For example, one design handed in for this class was for "gemini.com," a site for parents of twins. So you might begin your scenario with, "Susan is Mom to identical twin boys, age 5 months. Her double stroller has broken, even though it's relatively new. Looking for recommendations on a more reliable brand, she...." In this scenario, you might go on to describe how she found the site looking for a stroller purchase, but then stayed to engage in a BBS discussion about whether to dress identical twins alike.

5. Competitive Analysis

What other sites like this already exist? How will your site be different from existing sites? Talk about your competitive advantage.

6. Ethical Reflections

Include a section on potential risks and harms your community might introduce and how you will address those. If you cannot prevent potential harms, it might mean that you should not design this online community.

7. References & Appendices

List references that you cite in your write-up. If needed, you can have other material in appendices. Please use APA style to format your report and its bibliography: You can find a sample format [here](#). You won't earn points for including references appropriately, but you will lose points if you do not include them in your submissions properly.

8. Contribution statement

Provide a brief and accurate description of who on the team did which parts of the assignment. You won't earn points for including a contribution statement, but you will lose 0.5 point if you do not include this in your submissions.

You will be graded on the following qualities:

- Insight into research issues about the design of online communities.
- Description of the sociotechnical processes behind the design of the community, including the evidence provided for claims, and thoughtful engagement with scholarship and ethical issues
- The look and feel of the prospectus, its "interestingness"
- Spelling, grammar, narrative clarity, following instructions, etc.

Rubric

Elevator pitch A clear overview of the community, audience, and business model is provided.	4 pts
Design The design of the community is clearly communicated and supports the chosen target audience. Literature and/or concepts from class are used to support the design decisions.	8 pts
Mockups One overall app or site mockup is provided with consistent branding (colors, typography). Different pages/screens are provided that clearly showcase design decisions. 2 screens per team member are provided.	8 pts
User scenarios Two user scenarios (about 100 words each) are provided and tell a story of someone using the site. The scenarios clearly connect to your target audience(s) and demonstrate how they might interact with the online community.	2 pts
Competitive analysis At least one competitor is identified, and it is clear why they are a competitor. Competitive advantage communicates how the site will be different than the competition.	2 pts

Ethical reflections Thoughtful reflection of risks and harms that the community might present, and how they could be addressed. Literature and/or concepts from class are used to support.	3 pts
Contribution statement Contribution statements provided for each team member that clearly state who did which parts of the assignment. ** If you use ChatGPT or other AI-assisted writing tools, you MUST include this in your Contribution statement. Explain clearly how the software was used and confirm that one of your team members has edited the output.	-0.5 pts if not submitted
**Overall Writing Clarity/Proofreading Papers should be written in full sentence form, avoiding passive voice as much as possible, with no typographical or other errors. References and appendices are in correct APA format.	Up to -5 pts for poorly written or errors

Design Track's Final Slide Deck and Presentation [6% of final grade]

Prepare and submit a slide deck that illustrates your design assignment for Apr 21. If you use Google slides or other online collaborative tools, please do *not* submit a link. Export it as a powerpoint or PDF and submit that. The project slides will be shown on your laptop during the final presentations. You should design for 16:9 landscape Full HD (1920x1080p) widescreen resolution. The design and the layout of the slides is open for creativity. Your slide or slide deck should include the following:

- Your project's name
- The names of all team members
- Main points from the required report sections: elevator pitch, mockups, user scenarios (just 1 is enough), competitive analysis, ethical reflections, and contribution statement for the presentation/slides -- you don't have to include in this order; do what makes sense to you. The main purpose of the presentations is to showcase to the class what you have been working on this term.
- You will NOT present your contribution statement, we do want to have it on a slide. You won't earn points for including a contribution statement, but you will lose 0.5 point if you do not include this in your slides.

Not all team members need to talk as part of the presentation, but at least 2 team members should. You do not need to include every single detail that you have included in your report in your presentation, but just the highlights so that we can understand what you have done, how you have done it, and what problem you wanted to address.

Note: student presentations will be very short (**5-10 minutes**), so you will need to be very concise. **You should have a script and rehearse your presentation.** Because we have limited time, we will have to ask you to stop if you go over 10 minutes.

Rubric

Elevator pitch Overview of the online community, who it's for, and how it will be sustained financially.	1 pts
Design + Mockups	1 pts

The design of the online community and how it would function. Mockups provided to communicate key points of the design.	
User scenarios A brief overview of how someone from the target audience might use this community.	1 pts
Competitive analysis Similar sites that exist and your community's competitive advantage.	1 pts
Ethical reflections Potential risks or harm that this community might introduce, and how you address them.	1 pts
Layout of slide deck and Narrative The presentation engages the audience with a clear structure and a balanced mix of visuals and content in the slide decks	1 pt
Contribution statement Please provide a brief and accurate description of who on the team did which parts of the assignment.	-0.5 if not submitted

Research Track's Final Assignment Paper [27% of final grade]

Overview

For this assignment due on Apr 15, you will propose a research study of online communities, one that would lead to a journal paper of publishable quality if it were carried out -- this means, something that would add meaningful, novel, knowledge to the body of scholarly literature and is well-motivated and done. This track may be of particular interest to those who want to do a master's thesis or get a PhD, or find research roles after graduation. Please submit it as a PDF on Canvas and include all contributing team members' names in the submission.

Your research proposal should include the following elements:

1. Introduction
2. Literature review
3. Proposed methods
4. Discussion
5. References and appendices
6. Contribution statement

1. Introduction

You will need to motivate the study, show how this study would contribute to what we already know about online communities, and show how this study addresses an important research question. It's very important to begin with a strong rationale for why this study matters.

2. Literature review

This is the major part of this deliverable. Using both in class readings and your own literature review, summarize previous research and relevant theories that are important for understanding your research question and study. You're constructing this to **prove** that you are really approaching a novel problem and contributing new insights or understanding as opposed to answering a question that has already been addressed. The literature review should lead to clearly articulated hypotheses or research questions that your method can address. As a rule of thumb, you should have between 20-40 citations here. Check with

us if you're uncertain what would count. For example, Wikipedia articles or blog posts do not count, but you can have just a few popular press articles if you want.

3. Proposed methods

This should be a very detailed description of the methods you will use to answer your question, including information about how you would collect data and analyze them.

Some notes:

It's not enough to say something like "I'll do a survey of users." You need to clearly explain how you will recruit participants, how many participants you'll recruit, and the specific questions you'll ask (Add (questionnaire items). Same with any other method you propose. For example, if you say you will do interviews, be specific about that.

It should be in the realm of the possible. If you say something like "I'll use Facebook server data to analyze posting patterns of Moms" you need to show how you would get that particular dataset (which is not publicly available). You can assume you will have some funding, but do not have access to unlimited funds.

Feel free to use references in this section to justify specific methods. For instance, if you think a cognitive walkthrough is the right method to use to address your question, cite a piece that argues this.

Discuss any ethical considerations in carrying out the study.

4. Discussion

It is a bit awkward to have a discussion section for a paper without results, but use your imagination! Include a short section where you reiterate what you would expect to find for your study, why it is important or interesting and how your findings would contribute to related areas of studies. Please also include a small section on the limitations introduced by your choice of method. You can imagine that your audience is a funding agency, and they want to know what your study will contribute to and why that would matter if they gave you money to conduct it.

5. References & Appendices

List references that you cite in your write-up. If needed, you can have questionnaires or similar material in appendices. You can also include information that is too extra and/or detailed for the text of the paper itself but helpful to explain your argument and idea in appendices.

Please use APA style to format your paper and its bibliography: You can find a sample format [here](#). It should not be more than 15 pages long (double space), not including a cover page, a list of references and appendix at the end of the paper (easy to get there with double spacing).

You won't earn points for including references appropriately, but you will lose points if you do not include them in your submissions properly.

6. Contribution statement

Please provide a brief and accurate description of who on the team did which parts of the assignment. You won't earn points for including a contribution statement, but you will lose 0.5 point if you do not include this in your submissions.

What does a good paper look like?

- There is a compelling nature to the research question
 - Makes a contribution to the existing literature. The research question is concrete (not overly vague) or too broad. It should also be well-connected to the topics of the course and online communities.
- The topic is covered well through the literature review. The narrative argument is strong and connects the research question/hypotheses to the proposed method. Statements made in the

- literature review are supported by evidence/citations from previous literature.
- The method is reasonable and well-justified in the text. The method should be very specific. For example, if you argue to use an interview, list questions you would ask and a protocol you would follow.
- The paper should be well-written, with careful sentence construction and well-written sections. APA style should be appropriately used. Headers and signposting help structure the paper.

Rubric

Introduction A strong rationale for why this study matters is provided. Includes motivation, contribution, and the overarching research question(s).	5 pts
Literature review Uses both in-class readings and other scholarly literature to prove that you are really approaching a novel problem and contributing new insights. Clearly articulated hypotheses or research questions that your method can address.	8 pts
Proposed methods Proposed methods are clearly explained, with specifics about how you would collect the data and analyze it. A thoughtful ethical reflection of the potential risks and harms is provided. Scholarly literature and/or concepts from class are used to support.	**6 pts
Discussion Clearly reiterates expected findings for the study, why it is important or interesting, and how these findings would contribute to the field. Limitations of the proposed method are clearly stated. Support from relevant literature is provided.	**8 pts
Contribution Statement Contribution statements provided for each team member that clearly state who did which parts of the assignment. ** If you use ChatGPT or other AI-assisted writing tools, you MUST include this in your Contribution statement. Explain clearly how the software was used and confirm that one of your team members has edited the output.	-0.5 if not submitted
**Overall Writing Clarity/Proofreading Papers should be written in full sentence form, avoiding passive voice as much as possible, with no typographical or other errors. References and appendices are in correct APA format.	Up to -5 pts for poorly written or errors

Research Track's Final Slide Deck and Presentation [6% of final grade]

Prepare and submit a slide deck for Apr 15 that illustrates your assignment's main points. If you use Google slides or other online collaborative tools, please do *not* submit a link. Export it as a powerpoint or PDF and submit that. The project slides will be shown on your laptop during the final presentations. You should design for 16:9 landscape Full HD (1920x1080p) widescreen resolution. The design and the layout of the slides is open for creativity. Your slide or slide deck should include the following:

- Your project's name
- The names of all contributing team members

- Main points from the required paper sections: introduction, literature review, proposed methods, discussion, and contribution statement.
- You will NOT present your contribution statement, we just want to have it on a slide. You won't earn points for including a contribution statement, but you will lose 0.5 point if you do not include this in your slides.

Not all team members need to talk as part of the presentation, but at least 2 team members should. You do not need to include every single detail that you have included in your paper in your presentation, but just the highlights and provide us with a takeaway. **You should include a contribution statement for your slides/presentations.**

Note: student presentations will be very short (5 minutes), so you will need to be very concise. **You should have a script and rehearse your presentation.** Because we have limited time, we will have to ask you to stop if you go over 5 minutes.

Rubric

Introduction Research question(s), motivations for the study, and expected contributions to the field. A rationale for why this study matters.	1 pts
Literature review Previous research and theories that are important to understand your research question(s). Clear hypotheses or research questions that your method can address.	2 pts
Proposed methods Proposed methods that could be used to answer your research question(s). Any ethical considerations related to the method(s).	1 pts
Discussion Summarize expected findings, why it is interesting or important, and how this study might contribute to the field. Limitations of proposed methods.	1 pts
Layout of slide deck and Narrative The presentation engages the audience with a clear structure and a balanced mix of visuals and content in the slide decks	1 pts
Contribution statement Please provide a brief and accurate description of who on the team did which parts of the assignment.	-0.5 if not submitted

Recommended Readings

* All required readings are included in the [course schedule](#). Below list some recommended readings for each week – feel free to read those at your discretion to support your class projects.

W1. Intro to communities

Recommended (optional):

- [How to Read a Paper](#) by S. Keshav. ACM SIGCOMM Computer Communication Review, 2007.

- Chapter 4: Communities and Networks (pages 81-110) in *Personal Connections in the Digital Age* by Nancy Baym. Polity Press, 2015. [PDF available on Canvas]
- [Lurker demographics: counting the silent](#) by Blair Nonnecke and Jenny Preece. Proceedings of CHI 2000, April 2000, pp. 73-80.
- [A New Perspective on "Community" and its Implications for Computer-Mediated Communication Systems](#) by Amy Bruckman. Proceedings of CHI 2006, April 2006, pp. 616-621.
- [Feed me: motivating newcomer contribution in social network sites](#) by Moira Burke, Cameron Marlow, and Thomas Lento. Proceedings of CHI 2009, April 2009, pp. 945-954.
- [Bowling Alone: America's Declining Social Capital](#) by Robert Putnam. Journal of Democracy, 1995.
- [Motivations to participate in online communities](#) by Cliff Lampe, Rick Wash, Alcides Velasquez, and Elif Ozkaya. Proceedings of CHI 2010, April 2010, pp. 1927-1936.

W2. Ethics of studying and designing online communities/Black Mirror Workshop

Recommended (optional):

- [The Belmont Report](#). Department of Health, Education, and Welfare.
- [Beyond the Belmont Principles: Ethical Challenges, Practices, and Beliefs in the Online Data Research Community](#) by Jessica Vitak, Katie Shilton, and Zahra Ashktorab. CSCW '16, February 2016, pp. 941-953.
- [Accounting for Privacy in Citizen Science: Ethical Research in a Context of Openness](#) by Anne Bowser, Katie Shilton, Jennifer Preece, and Elizabeth Warrick. CSCW '17, February 2017, pp. 2124-2136.
- Chapter 8: Ethics (pages 129-150), in [Ethnography and Virtual Worlds: A Handbook of Method](#) by Tom Boellstorff, Bonnie Nardi, Celia Pearce, and T. L. Taylor. Princeton University Press, 2013.
- [Ethical use of visual social media content in research publications - AHRECS](#)
- Recommendations for Ethical Disguise of Online Sources - <https://reagle.org/joseph/2020/spin/disguise-recommendations.html>
- [Spinning words as disguise: Shady services for ethical research?](#)

W3. Design and online communities

No recommended readings.

W4. Identity and online communities

Recommended (optional):

- [Identity and Deception in the Virtual Community](#) by Judith Donath.
- Pages 1-58 (intro and most of chapter 1), in [The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life](#) by Erving Goffman. Doubleday, 1956. [Available in the Files section of Canvas].
- Embodied verification: Linking identities and bodies on NSFW Reddit (pages 51-64) by Emily van der Nagel. In [Mediated Interfaces: The Body on Social Media](#), Edited by Katie Warfield, Crystal Abidin, and Carolina Cambre. Bloomsbury Academic & Professional, 2020.

- [The Politics of 'Real Names': Power, Context, and Controlling Networked Publics](#) by danah boyd. Communications of the ACM 55(8), pp. 29-31.
- [We need online alter egos now more than ever](#) by Judith Donath. Wired Magazine, 2014.

W5. Regulation and moderation of online communities

Recommended (optional):

- Schoenbeck, S., Haimson, O., & Nakamura, L. (2020). [Drawing from Justice Theories to Support Targets of Online Harassment](#). New Media & Society, 23(5), 1278-1300.
- [Content Moderation Is Particularly Hard in African Countries](#) by Tomiwa Ilori. Slate, 2020.
- [Hate Raids on Twitch: Echoes of the Past, New Modalities, and Implications for Platform Governance](#) by Catherine Han, Joseph Seering, Deepak Kumar, and Jeffrey T. Hancock. Proc. ACM Hum.- Comput. Interact. 7, CSCW1, Article 133, April 2023.
- [Squadbox: A Tool to Combat Email Harassment Using Friendsourced Moderation](#) by Kaitlin Mahar, Amy X. Zhang, and David Karger. Proceedings of CHI 2018, April 2018, pp. 1-13.
- Chapter 4: Regulating Behavior in Online Communities (pages 125-170), in [Building Successful Online Communities: Evidence-Based Social Design](#) by Robert Kraut and Paul Resnick. The MIT Press, 2012.
- [Decolonizing Tactics as Collective Resilience: Identity Work of AAPI Communities on Reddit](#) by Bryan Dosono and Bryan Semaan. CSCW '20, May 2020, pp. 1-20
- [Designing Good Policy for Online Platforms and Communities](#) by Cindy Au. Medium, 2015.
- [Custodians of the Internet](#) by Tarleton Gillespie. Yale University Press, 2018.
- [Moderation Challenges in Voice-based Online Communities on Discord](#) by Jialun Jiang, Charles Kiene, Skyler Middler, Jed Brubaker, and Casey Fiesler. CSCW '19, November 2019, pp. 1-23. .
- [Social Media Content Moderation: Six Opportunities for Feminist Intervention](#) by Ysabel Gerrard. In Feminist Media Studies, 2020.

W6. Marginalization and online communities (disability, experience, race, gender)

Recommended (optional):

- [“We ‘said her name’ and got zucked”: Black Women Calling-out the Carceral Logics of Digital Platforms](#) by Kishonna L. Gray and Krysten Stein. *Gender & Society* 35, 4:, 2021, pp. 538–545.
- [Entrepreneurial Solidarities: Social Media Collectives and Filipino Digital Platform Workers](#) by Cheryll Ruth Soriano and Jason Vincent Cabañes. Social Media + Society, 2020.
- [Class Confessions: Restorative Properties in Online Experiences of Socioeconomic Stigma](#) by Eugenia Ha Rim Rho, Oliver Haimson, Nazanin Andalibi, Melissa Mazmanian, and Gillian Hayes. Proceedings of CHI 2017, May 2017, pp. 3377-3389.
- [Deviant bodies, stigmatized identities, and racist acts: examining the experiences of African-American gamers in Xbox Live](#) by Kishonna L. Gray. New Review of Hypermedia and Multimedia, 2012.

W7. Online Community Study Presentations

No readings.

Online community study presentations by student teams.

W8. Algorithms and online communities

Recommended (optional):

- [“I Always Assumed That I Wasn’t Really That Close to \[Her\]”: Reasoning About Invisible Algorithms in News Feeds](#) by Motahhare Eslami, Aimee Rickman, Kristen Vaccaro, Amirhossein Aleyasen, Andy Vuong, Karrie Karahalios, Kevin Hamilton, and Christian Sandvig. Proceedings of CHI 2015, April 2015, pp. 153-162
- [Algorithms ruin everything: #RIPTwitter, Folk Theories, and Resistance to Algorithmic Change in Social Media](#) by Michael Ann DeVito, Darren Gergle, and Jeremy Birnholtz. Proceedings of CHI 2017, May 2017, pp. 3163-3174.

W9. Spring Break

No readings.

W10. Wellbeing and online communities

Recommended (optional):

- High, Andrew C., et al. "[Computer-mediated communication and well-being in the age of social media: A systematic review](#)." Journal of Social and Personal Relationships 40.2 (2023): 420-458.
- Ellison, Nicole B., Cassidy Pyle, and Jessica Vitak. "[Scholarship on well-being and social media: A sociotechnical perspective](#)." Current Opinion in Psychology 46 (2022): 101340.
- Abeele, Mariek MP Vanden, Annabell Halfmann, and Edmund WJ Lee. "[Drug, demon, or donut? Theorizing the relationship between social media use, digital well-being and digital disconnection](#)." Current Opinion in Psychology 45 (2022): 101295.
- Valkenburg, Patti M. "[Social media use and well-being: What we know and what we need to know](#)." Current Opinion in Psychology 45 (2022): 101294.
- Orben, Amy, and Sarah-Jayne Blakemore. "[How social media affects teen mental health: a missing link](#)." Nature 614.7948 (2023): 410-412.
- [LGBTQ Persons’ Use of Online Spaces to Navigate Conception, Pregnancy, and Pregnancy Loss: An Intersectional Approach](#) by Nazanin Andalibi, Ashley Lacombe-Duncan, Lee Roosevelt, Kylie Wojciechowski, and Cameron Giniel. TOCHI 2022
- [Sensemaking and Coping After Pregnancy Loss: The Seeking and Disruption of Emotional Validation Online](#) by Nazanin Andalibi and Paricia Garcia. CSCW’ 21
- [Instagram photos reveal predictive markers of depression](#) by Andrew G. Reece and Christopher M. Danforth. EPJ Data Science 6, 1: 1–12, 2017. [okay to skim]

- [Sensitive Self-disclosures, Responses, and Social Support on Instagram: The Case of #Depression](#) by Nazanin Andalibi, Pinar Ozturk, and Andrea Forte. CSCW '17, February 2017, pp. 321-337.
- [Disclosure, Stress, and Support During Gender Transition on Facebook](#) by Oliver Haimson, Jed Brubaker, Lynn Dombrowski, and Gillian Hayes. CSCW '15, March 2015, pp. 1176-1190.
- [Write for Life: Persisting in Online Health Communities through Expressive Writing and Social Support](#) by Haiwei Ma, C. Estelle Smith, Lu He, Saumik Narayanan, Robert Giaquinto, Roni Evans, Linda Hanson, and Svetlana Yarosh. CSCW '17, November 2017, pp. 1-24.

W11. Abuse, harassment, and extremism and online communities

Recommended (optional):

- [“We Dissect Stupidity and Respond to It”: Response Videos and Networked Harassment on YouTube](#) by Rebecca Lewis, Alice Marwick, and William Clyde Partin. American Behavioral Scientist, 2021.
- Watch: [The Internet is a trash fire. Here's how to fix it.](#) by Lisa Nakamura. TED, 2019.
- [Inside the “Pro-ana” Community: A Covert Online Participant Observation](#) by Sarah Brotsky and David C Giles. Eating Disorders, pp. 93-109, 2007. [TW: *disordered eating*]
- [Hollaback: The role of storytelling online in a social movement organization](#). By Jill Dimond, Michaelanne Dye, Daphne LaRose, Amy S. Bruckman. 2013. CSCW
- [Stormfront is like a second home to me](#) by De Koster and Dick Houtman. Information, Communication & Society, 2008.
- [Lexicon of Lies: Terms for Problematic Information](#) by Caroline Jack. Data & Society, 2017.
- [Twitter and White Supremacy, A Love Story](#) by Jessie Daniels. Dame Magazine, 2017.

W12. Access, Constraint, and (Online) Communities of Survival

Recommended (optional):

- [“You Can Connect with Like, the World!”: Social Platforms, Survival Support, and Digital Inequalities for People Experiencing Homelessness](#), By Will Marler, *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*, Volume 27, Issue 1, January 2022, zma020,
- ["Facebook in Venezuela: understanding solidarity economies in low-trust environments."](#) By Evans, Hayley I., Marisol Wong-Villacres, Daniel Castro, Eric Gilbert, Rosa I. Arriaga, Michaelanne Dye, and Amy Bruckman. In *Proceedings of the 2018 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, pp. 1-12. 2018.
- [The Chinese Diaspora and The Attempted WeChat Ban: Platform Precarity, Anticipated Impacts, and Infrastructural Migration](#). By Zhang, B. Z., Haimson, O. L., & Thomas, M. (2022). *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*, 6(CSCW2), 1-29.

W13. Misinformation, conspiracy theories, and online communities

Recommended (optional):

- [Measuring Misinformation in Video Search Platforms: An Audit Study on YouTube](#) by Eslam Hussein, Perna Juneja, and Tanushree Mitra. Proceedings of the ACM on CSCW '20, May 2020, pp. 1-27.

- [Constructing alternative facts: Populist expertise and the QAnon conspiracy](#) by Alice E Marwick and William Clyde Martin. *New Media & Society*, 2022.

<i>W14. Final project presentations</i>
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No readings.

**Note:* Some elements of this syllabus are adopted from syllabi by Amy Bruckman at Georgia Tech and previous/other UMSI Online Communities instructors (Naz Andalibi, Cliff Lampe, Sarita Schoenebeck, Nicole Ellison, and Eric Gilbert). The Black Mirror assignment in the Ethics Week is adapted from Casey Fiesler.